

report shows an improvement of 5-6 percentage points to 16-18 per cent representation across the Nifty 500 companies as of 2020. "I do see companies appointing women to nomination & remuneration committees, but their appointment to audit committees may not be very frequent," says Shroff. "The reality is that a lot of the women selected for board positions are not with that kind of audit expertise," says Vohra. Raut adds that women would benefit from acquiring a basic understanding of the balance sheet and sustainable investment planning.

no reason why first-time women directors need to undergo special training which their male counterparts don't need to."

But what really helps women to be more effective board members is critical mass. "There is enough and more evidence to say that to really make a big difference, you need at least two to three women on the board. Otherwise, the voice of a single woman gets drowned," says Bali. Duggal agrees. "A quarter to 33 per cent of your board has to be women directors to enhance the impact of having women on them."



"Companies need to realise that younger women have a lot to offer as directors. We who are senior women on boards should also encourage boards to appoint younger women as directors"

PALLAVI SHROFF
MANAGING PARTNER, SHARDUL
AMARCHAND MANGALDAS & CO



EY data shows that about 60 per cent of the Nifty 500 companies have just one woman board member

The Way Forward

Networking is one of the best ways for women to get into more boards. That's how the men do it, say experts. These days, several networks run workshops, mentor women and enable their board placements. Raut says women's participation in his organisation's programmes has risen steadily over the past four to five years, with 25 per cent of every batch now being women. Speaking strictly about professional board appointments, Bali has a different view. "If we are selecting members based on competence, there is

He sees the jump from the current 18 per cent representation to 25 per cent as being crucial. "Once that happens, it will become automatic (where it starts becoming the norm to have more women on company boards)." Along the way, sensitisation of the small and big things is much needed. For instance, Vohra points out, the standard issue green-notary stamp still says 'Chairman' and not 'Chairperson'. "We should have fixed it by now. Every time I get such a paper, I replace 'Chairman' with 'Chairperson' and then sign."



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VINITA BALI
FORMER MD & CEO,
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